



## SUCCESS SKILL: COLLABORATION

### BACKGROUND

This rubric is aligned with the [NCIES literature review](#) on collaboration. The value proposition is a clear research-based definition of collaboration as a success skill. This research-based rubric<sup>1</sup> is designed to provide useful, formative information that teachers can use to guide instruction and provide feedback to students and that they can use to reflect on the quality of their peer interactions. In this rubric, student performance is described along a continuum and balances content-specific and the more general nature of collaboration. Rubrics are provided by grade span, K-2, 3-5, and 6-12. The K-2 rubric includes both a teacher version and a version for primary students or early readers. The research-based definition of collaboration, identified in the literature review, embraces the concept of *collaboration as a process*:

**“Students work in groups to improve their ability to work with others, and the quality of student interactions therefore should be the focus of teaching and learning. To be sure, intellectual gain and increased academic content knowledge and skill could be a bi- or co-product of collaborative activity, but this is not the focus either of instruction or of assessment related to collaboration. Rather, the focus is on the nature and quality of the collaborative activity and the interactions among group members” (Evans, 2020, p5).**

### BUILDING COLLABORATION SKILLS THROUGH CULTURALLY- RELEVANT GOLD STANDARD PBL

- **Use Gold Standard Project Based Teaching Practices to support students’ development of collaborative skills within a project.** Teachers can build a culture of collaboration by explicitly and implicitly promoting student interdependence and growth, open-ended inquiry, teamwork, and attention to quality. To manage activities, teachers work with students to organize tasks and schedules, set checkpoints and deadlines, find and use resources, and create products. Within the context of a project, teachers also intentionally scaffold [collaboration skills](#) through targeted instruction, tools, and practices that help students learn and practice strategies for working well together in teams. Throughout the project, teachers monitor and regulate student interactions to gather evidence of collaboration. [PBLWorks Strategy Guides](#) located on [my.pblworks.org](#) offer multiple resources to address instructional strategies that support collaboration.
- **Use research-based guidance to assess collaboration.** Throughout the project, teachers monitor and support student interactions to gather evidence of collaboration. To assess the quality of student interactions, Evans (2020) suggests that tasks need to:
  - **Be sufficiently complex.** Make the design rigorous and frame it with a challenging problem or meaningful question at the appropriate level of challenge. The design should be challenging enough to elicit group discussion, negotiation, and collective efforts.
  - **Be open-ended.** Open-ended tasks require students to determine what is relevant, plan how they will demonstrate their knowledge, and offer multiple pathways for solutions. Open ended tasks “allow for multiple, defensible solutions and, further, require students to apply (or transfer) their learning to novel situations” (p. 18).
  - **Be authentic.** Using the Gold Standard Design Element, Authenticity, in project design provides students with opportunities to engage with real-world contexts, tasks, tools, or impact. The PBLWorks Blog, [What Does it Take for a Project to be “Authentic”?](#) is a helpful resource for planning.
  - **Be reflective of culture and context.** [PBL supports culturally responsive teaching practices](#), and it is important to note that while assessing the quality of student interactions cultural differences must be considered. Some differences are verbal, what is considered appropriate communication and sharing of resources, ideas, or efforts; other differences are non-verbal and mediate what is considered appropriate body language, conflict resolution, and task management tactics. Verbal and non-verbal interactions may vary across cultural contexts.
  - **Make student thinking visible.** Offer students opportunities to make their thinking visible to their group. Use [Structured reflections](#) to do this.

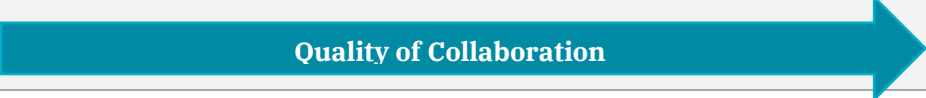
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<sup>1</sup> These rubrics were created by National Center for Improvement of Educational Assessment (Center for Assessment) in collaboration with PBLWorks. This version of the rubric integrates asset-based language based on the *Ready for Rigor: A Framework for Culturally Responsive Teaching* (Hammond, 2013).



### Collaboration: Grade 3-5

*Collaboration occurs when students work together to complete a project and must combine thinking, skills, and efforts to do so.*

| DIMENSION                                         |                                                                                                                                                                                                              |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                               |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                 |
|---------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
|                                                   | <i>Select the column where most of the criteria that describe what a student knows and can do independently.</i>                                                                                                                                                                               |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                               |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                 |
|                                                   | BEGINNING                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                      | EMERGING                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                       | DEVELOPING                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                    | DEMONSTRATING                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                   |
| <b>Planning and Group Decision-Making</b>         | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>Identifies one “right” way to complete the project.</li> <li>Agrees to do the task given by the group and does it their own way.</li> <li>Expresses frustration causing group conflict if someone offers suggestions for how to do the work.</li> </ul> | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>Retells how others in the group want to complete the project.</li> <li>Volunteers a way that they could help the group.</li> <li>Self-manages during group disagreements about the project or if group members are off task.</li> </ul> | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>Adds their thoughts about how to manage or complete the project.</li> <li>Suggests roles or tasks for group members that are equitable.</li> <li>Helps the group figure out a disagreement or stay on-task.</li> </ul> | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>Suggests ways that help the group manage or complete the project.</li> <li>Suggests roles or tasks based on the abilities or interests of those in the group.</li> <li>Suggests ways the group can make decisions when there is disagreement.</li> </ul> |
| <b>Communicating About Thinking</b>               | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>Engages in discussion mostly about their own ideas.</li> </ul>                                                                                                                                                                                          | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>Retells the ideas that others shared.</li> </ul>                                                                                                                                                                                        | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>Asks questions to help clarify the ideas of others.</li> </ul>                                                                                                                                                         | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>Identifies when ideas do not make sense.</li> <li>Asks what others think.</li> <li>Uses academic language to talk about their learning moves.</li> </ul>                                                                                                 |
| <b>Contributing Resources, Ideas, and Efforts</b> | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>Focuses on what they are told to do.</li> <li>Completes their part of the group project on time.</li> <li>Lets each person decide what they need on their own.</li> </ul>                                                                               | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>Identifies the ideas and resources they need to complete the work.</li> <li>Asks the group what resources they have.</li> <li>Shares their work and looks at others’ work at the end of the project.</li> </ul>                         | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>Brainstorms ideas with the group.</li> <li>Finds resources for others, when asked.</li> <li>Asks if anyone needs help or feedback during the project.</li> </ul>                                                       | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>Suggests important ideas to help improve the project.</li> <li>Provides resources to support the group.</li> <li>Helps others and gives feedback throughout the project.</li> </ul>                                                                      |
| <b>Monitoring Processes</b>                       | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>Focuses on getting their part of the group project done.</li> </ul>                                                                                                                                                                                     | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>Identifies how their work shows quality.</li> </ul>                                                                                                                                                                                     | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>Monitors the group’s project quality and process throughout the project.</li> </ul>                                                                                                                                    | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>Reflects on and suggests ways the group can improve the quality and process of the project next time.</li> <li>Makes a plan for improving their work next time.</li> </ul>                                                                               |